

hopeful about getting the opportunity to make another Nexus device, as our Nexus 7 tablet has done very well.

Q The Asus-Google Nexus 7 is available online in India at a price of Rs 19,999. Do you think the Nexus 7 is suited for the Indian market?

A Nexus device offers a completely different experience from any other brand. The overall outlook of a Nexus device is way better than any other tablet in the market. In Europe, we are among the top three players due to Nexus 7. I don't think there is any other product that can give an experience similar to that of the Nexus 7 at the same price point.

Q So why has it not been officially launched in India yet, though anyone who wishes to can either buy it online or even at one of the stores in New Delhi?

We are still working on the official launch of the device. We will keep the fans of Nexus updated about the official launch.

Q On the connectivity front, the Nexus 7 is a 'Wi-Fi only' model, so the tablet may not be liked by many buyers in India as GSM connectivity in the form of dongles is more popular than Wi-Fi in the country.

We are planning to launch the 3G version of the Nexus 7 in India.

Q When can we expect the Nexus 7 3G to come to India?

Hopefully, we will launch the tablet by the first half of 2013.

Q At what price will it be available here?

Pricing is yet to be worked out. Looking at the market of a 17.7-cm (7-inch) tablet in India, the price could be roughly around Rs 20,000.

Q What are the key things you look for before launching a product in the Indian market?

Product-wise, we try to launch the devices in India shortly after launching them globally. In India, the premium sales do exist, but we also try to keep our focus on value for money. We have a lot of products in India, which offer good value for the money spent. Even in the low end segment, we prioritise on the designs of the product. The Indian market is different just because Indians really research a lot about a product before buying it, which, in a way, is good for us as they will understand Asus better.

Q Android has been around for a long time. But now you have more open source operating systems to explore, including Ubuntu's and the Firefox operating system for smartphones. Do you feel there is enough potential in the newly launched operating systems?

It's too early to talk about these operating systems. They have just been launched. We will have to wait and watch out for further developments. But at the moment, we would be focusing on Android for our products. We don't have any plans to work on Firefox or Ubuntu, as of now.

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Q You are expanding your retail presence by opening stores across India at a very fast pace. What is the strategy behind such rapid launches of Asus stores across Tier I, II and III towns in India?

Since the last two years, we have always been focused on coming up with new stores because we believe a channel is very important if you want to grow in India. Even in 2013, we will continue to expand our channels in the country. We want to have 200 Asus stores across India by the end of 2013. As the consumer awareness is growing, consumers in Tier III or Tier IV cities in India are learning about Asus. Brand consciousness is slowly growing in rural areas as well. So, people want to feel the difference in a branded product, which makes the presence of physical stores very important. Also, after sales service is a very important factor, which is associated with branding. So, our stores will help in reaching out to more people. Thus, a store is an ideal marketing tool. Asus is becoming popular in smaller cities and towns across India. We are getting more sales from Tier II and Tier III cities across the country than metro cities. Places like Hubli in Karnataka and Durgapur in West Bengal have amazed us with high sales figures. We, at Asus, are observing that the Tier II and III cities are slowly leading in sales of tablets as compared to their urban counterparts.

Q Yet another much-talked about device from Asus is Padfone. It's a phone-cum-tablet-cum-laptop. But if you look at it as an individual product, it is just a phone, which can power a bigger screen if fitted into it and can support a keyboard too. So the tablet part doesn't work without the phone being inserted in it. What is the strategy behind designing a product like Padfone?

At Asus, we take design and innovation seriously. We like to experiment with new types of products and see how the market responds to it. The idea behind launching Padfone is to cater to the people who want a good smartphone as well as a tablet in a single device. The device is meant for those people who want to have the experience of a smartphone on a large screen. For example, when you are travelling, if you carry the Padfone, then you just have to plug in the device to the supplied display screen to enjoy movies or work on a large screen. Also, we wanted to come up with a completely different kind of hybrid product.

Q When can we expect the Padfone 2 smartphone-cum-tablet in India?

We had launched the original Padfone in India last year. Mobile phone is a new product for us. So, our idea is to open the channel with Padfone first, and then expand our

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